Don't Trash That Pumpkin: Give It a Second Life

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Every fall, tens of millions of pumpkins show up on doorsteps and porches across the United States. Some become spooky jack-o'-lanterns. Others simply sit outside as decorations. Then Halloween ends, and for most people, the pumpkin's job is done.

But that goodbye comes with a big hidden cost. Experts estimate that over one billion pounds of pumpkins end up in **landfills** each year in the United States. That is more than 80 percent of the 1.3 billion pounds purchased annually. The problem is not only in the United States. In the United Kingdom, about 55 percent of the 39 million pumpkins bought for the holiday go uneaten, adding up to about $37 million worth of food.

When pumpkins rot in **landfills**, they release **methane**, a greenhouse gas that traps much more heat than carbon dioxide over a shorter period. So a decoration that looked harmless on a porch can add to climate change once it is thrown away.

Fortunately, there is an easy fix, and it starts before you toss anything. If a pumpkin was used as decor, scoop out the edible insides. Roasted pumpkin seeds make a nutritious and tasty snack. The flesh can become a hearty soup, a creamy **puree**, or a delicious pie. You can also donate pumpkins to local farms or zoos, where they can be used as animal feed.

If a pumpkin is too far gone to eat or donate, bury it in your yard. It will naturally **decompose** and add **nutrients** to the soil. Giving an old pumpkin a second life is a small choice, but multiplied across millions of homes, it can help reduce waste and protect our environment.

Word Treasure

landfills -- A large place where trash is buried in the ground.

methane -- A gas that traps heat in the air and can warm the planet.

puree -- Food that has been mashed or blended until it is smooth and soft.

decompose -- To break down slowly into smaller parts over time.

nutrients -- Substances in soil or food that help living things grow and stay healthy.

Background you need

A pumpkin is a large orange fruit that grows in the fall and is often carved into a jack-o'-lantern or used as a decoration for Halloween.

After the holiday, many pumpkins are thrown away, and when food rots in a landfill without much air, it can release methane, a gas that traps heat in the atmosphere.

Instead of throwing a pumpkin away, its seeds and flesh can be eaten, it can be given to animals as feed, or it can be buried or composted so it breaks down and returns nutrients to the soil.

Break it down

LEAD: Every fall, tens of millions of pumpkins appear on doorsteps and porches across the United States, some as jack-o'-lanterns and others as decorations, and their job seems done when Halloween ends.

PROBLEM: Throwing pumpkins away creates a large hidden waste and climate cost.

+- SCALE IN THE UNITED STATES: Experts estimate that over one billion pounds of pumpkins end up in landfills each year, more than 80 percent of the 1.3 billion pounds purchased annually.

+- SCALE IN THE UNITED KINGDOM: About 55 percent of the 39 million pumpkins bought for the holiday go uneaten, adding up to about $37 million worth of food.

+- CLIMATE EFFECT: When pumpkins rot in landfills, they release methane, a greenhouse gas that traps much more heat than carbon dioxide over a shorter period.

SOLUTIONS: A pumpkin can be given a second life instead of being tossed.

+- EAT IT: Scoop out the edible insides; roasted seeds make a nutritious and tasty snack, and the flesh can become a hearty soup, a creamy puree, or a delicious pie.

+- DONATE IT: Donate pumpkins to local farms or zoos, where they can be used as animal feed.

+- BURY IT: If a pumpkin is too far gone to eat or donate, bury it in your yard so it naturally decomposes and adds nutrients to the soil.

CONCLUSION: A small choice, multiplied across millions of homes, can help reduce waste and protect the environment.

Why it matters

Pumpkin waste is not just a Halloween leftover problem: rotting pumpkins in landfills add methane to the atmosphere, so reusing, donating, or burying them is a small everyday choice that, multiplied across millions of homes, can reduce waste and help protect the environment.

Test what you remember

1. **According to the article, how many pounds of pumpkins end up in landfills each year in the United States?**
   - (A) About 55 percent of pumpkins bought
   - (B) About 39 million pounds
   - (C) Over one billion pounds
   - (D) $37 million worth of pumpkins
2. **What happens when pumpkins rot in landfills?**
   - (A) They freeze and stop decomposing
   - (B) They add nutrients to landfill soil
   - (C) They release methane, a greenhouse gas that traps much more heat than carbon dioxide over a shorter period
   - (D) They are turned into soup
3. **In the United Kingdom, what does the article say about pumpkins bought for the holiday?**
   - (A) All 39 million pumpkins are eaten
   - (B) About 55 percent of the 39 million pumpkins bought for the holiday go uneaten
   - (C) About $37 million of pumpkins are donated to zoos
   - (D) About 80 percent of pumpkins are composted
4. **Which of these is one use for pumpkin flesh mentioned in the article?**
   - (A) A hearty soup
   - (B) Roasted seeds only
   - (C) Animal feed for zoos
   - (D) Compost for a yard
5. **What should you do with a pumpkin that is too far gone to eat or donate?**
   - (A) Bury it in your yard, where it will naturally decompose and add nutrients to the soil
   - (B) Turn it into a pie
   - (C) Throw it in a landfill
   - (D) Donate it to a local farm
6. **Where can pumpkins be donated, according to the article?**
   - (A) To a grocery store
   - (B) To a landfill site
   - (C) To local farms or zoos, where they can be used as animal feed
   - (D) To a pumpkin patch

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: B 4: A 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):